

The Caribbean: A History of the Region and Its People

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A virtual kaleidoscope of cultures, languages, religious beliefs, and histories spread out over an amorphous geographical expanse, the Caribbean is a place of contrasts. It is also a challenging subject of study. Perhaps for these reasons, students and specialists of the archipelago and surrounding littoral have found it useful to focus their research and publications on specific historical periods, disciplinary approaches, and sub-regions, or to privilege certain topics, such as slavery or piracy, which are either deemed representative of the overall picture or simply more manageable. Breaking out of that historiographical mold, *The Caribbean: A History of the Region and its People* takes on the daunting task of surveying the entire area with an inclusive approach that merges the various methodologies, themes, and units of analysis into a comprehensive narrative.

In Part I, D. Barker surveys the varied geography of the Caribbean, calling attention to how its diverse landforms and other physical features widened or narrowed the choices available to the region's inhabitants and helped determine how and when certain quarters were settled, by whom, under what circumstances, for what purposes, and to what extent. L.A. Curet questions crude accounts of the earliest dwellers that focus principally on the arrival of successive indigenous waves from northern South America several thousand years ago. Drawing on the latest archeological and ethnobotanical findings he reveals a richer portrait in which sociocultural change is driven by interactions between the islands and the circum-Caribbean, but that also involved creative adaptations and creolization. W. D. Phillips retraces the origins of the plantation's sugar-slavery dyad to its Old World roots in the Mediterranean and the North Atlantic, from where it was transplanted to the Americas. As D. McGregor indicates, the rapacious post-1492 exploitation to which the region's limited natural resources were subjected—especially by commercial agriculture—has significantly constrained the options available to present-day Caribbean people and policymakers, who must strive to strike a balance between economic viability and ecological preservation.

The next section traces the manner by which the Iberian "discovery" of the Caribbean morphed into a European colonial quest overseas. R. Funes Monzote identifies the crucial forces that propelled the Spanish invasion of the Caribbean, among them the proliferation of long-distance maritime trade and the defeat of the

last Muslim stronghold in Granada. The selection of Asia as the next target of Europe's global mercantilist race inspired the Columbian transatlantic venture that set off the "great human and environmental tragedy in the Caribbean islands" (p. 95). J. Sued Badillo and L. Guitart examine the labor exploitation of Tainos, and to a lesser extent Africans, in 16th century Puerto Rico and Hispaniola, citing evidence of widespread marronage, negotiations, and armed resistance that debunks ethnocentric notions of native backwardness and acquiescence to European intrusion. S. Palmié outlines the trajectory followed by plantation-based agriculture as it journeyed from the North Atlantic to the Caribbean, taking note of its short-lived sojourn in the Spanish Antilles and re-emergence in the eastern Caribbean. Its eventual pairing with African slavery generated the sugar revolution that helped underwrite the South Atlantic System. I. Curtis shows that the ascendancy of the planter class was aggressively opposed by indigenous *cimarrones*, runaway indentured servants, pirates, buccaneers, and maroons of African descent who fashioned a "masterless" counterculture that undermined the plantocratic regimes and nurtured freedom in the Atlantic world.

Part 3 focuses on the Caribbean's changing social, political and economic role in the post-17th century Atlantic world. J. Fradera analyses the rise of competing imperial spheres of control, which started with the gradual decline of Iberian royal authority in the islands after about 1550. In its wake, European rivals gradually shifted from plundering to seizing enemy territories, eventually confining Spanish hegemony to Cuba, Santo Domingo, and Puerto Rico. A. Games places this turn of events in a wider Atlantic context marked by the prioritization of Spanish defense spending on the European theater. The tense atmosphere, F. Scarano tells us, produced a "bunker mentality" in the remaining Spanish-controlled islands; it also prompted their inhabitants to engage in smuggling, animal husbandry and subsistence farming. Meanwhile, as M.D. Beckles explains, the shift to sugar monoculture, infusion of capital and technology and planters' inability to transform white servants into chattel property in their quest for higher profits fostered the establishment of slave-based sugar plantations in the non-Hispanic Caribbean. P. Boucher cautions against overemphasizing the importance of sugar, given that some of the French and Dutch colonies advantageously pursued rival or complimentary economic activities, such coffee, indigo and cotton production, contraband, and slave trading. S. Carrington and R. Noel argue that the economic logic of the South Atlantic System during the slavery era was founded on a value-added economic premise that became unsustainable during the 19th century due to the combined impact of slave insurgency, wartime disruptions of trade, agricultural diversification, industrialization, and waged labor.

The intertwined history of capitalism, slavery, and revolution in the Caribbean occupies Part 4. P. Morgan explores the importance of slave cultures, paying particular attention to African ethnic retentions, Caribbean adaptations and regional variations, and how these practices informed the survival strategies of the enslaved. D. Hamilton documents the centrality of the Caribbean in four global wars fought partly there. Another bloody struggle, the Haitian Revolution (1791-1804), culminated in the establishment of the second independent state in the Americas and, as L. Dubois points out, helped redefine the meanings of liberty, human rights, and citizenship in the Atlantic world. In surveying the process of abolition in the non-Hispanic Caribbean, D. Paton stresses the self-serving strategies of European governments that sought to preserve and strengthen colonial rule by replacing bondage with other poorly disguised compulsory labor regimes, such as the apprenticeship system. D. Tomich counters S. Drescher's econocide thesis by persuasively arguing that British abolitionism was not a senseless act of economic self-destruction but a major readjustment driven by the pressures of industrialization, global market forces, and free trade. J. Besson underlines how the enslaved creatively engaged Christianity to assert their humanity, as symbolized by their creation of alternative cosmologies and the transformation of marginal provision grounds into sacred burial sites and proto-peasant parcels.

Part 5 considers the re-ordering of the Caribbean world just before and right after emancipation. C. Schmidt-Nowara tracks the relatively late arrival of the sugar revolution in Cuba and Puerto Rico and how British abolitionism, and fear of haitianization, separatists, free blacks, and peasants, contested the institutionalization of a "second slavery" in the Hispanic Caribbean. R. Whitney unravels the tangled connection between slavery and nation-building in Cuba and the Dominican Republic, which fueled a protracted war of liberation polarized by race and class in the former and an internal jockeying for political power among competing *caudillos* in the latter. Proposals for selling, leasing, or annexing all or part of both territories to the U.S. revealed the growing reach of U.S. power in this region which, as L. Martínez-Fernández shows, eventually transformed Central America and the Caribbean into the "American Mediterranean." G. Heuman assesses the impact of emancipation in the adjacent French and British colonies, where coercive labor regimes sparked labor unrest and the formation of free peasant villages. In response, planters replenished their dwindled workforce by luring free laborers from Africa, Asia, Europe, and the Levant. They also deployed, as E. Copper documents, racist theories of human development to justify the imposition of discriminatory practices on the ex-slaves. A. Khan describes how the new migratory waves culturally reconstructed the Caribbean, which by the 1930s boasted a bewildering array of ethnic groups, languages, religions, races, and socioeconomic classes.

"The New Empire," which is the focus of Part 6, probes the consequences of United States hegemony in the Caribbean. B. G. Plummer exposes the paternalistic and racist overtones of U.S. expansionism as reflected in social darwinist and progressivist notions that sought to justify military interventions, establishment of custom receiverships, imposition of protectorates, or the outright occupation of territories. C. J. Ayala details how U.S. capital and technology took over the sugar industry in the Hispanic Caribbean, converting it into an American sugar kingdom. W. James outlines the emergence of a Caribbean intellectual vanguard that actively challenged the North Americans' intrusion. O. Nigel Bolland recounts the Depression era's increase in labor activism, rebellions, and political mobilizations that triggered nationalist campaigns for colonial reform and/or independence in the post-1940s. As a result, as A. S. Macpherson lays out, of the thirty-six politico-administrative units that comprised the Caribbean, thirteen became sovereign states and six were "decolonized" but remained non-sovereign. D. Sheinin takes exception to explanations of Caribbean underdevelopment that one-sidedly emphasize Cold War politics. Rather, he suggests looking closer at local, regional and national impulses, which oscillate between reform and revolution, for the forces that reproduce and maintain it.

The concluding section brings the story of the Caribbean to the present. M. Zeuske reviews the key developments of the Cuban Revolution from 1959 to the present. A. P. Maingot discusses the failure of the British parliamentary system of independent Surinam, Trinidad/Tobago, and Jamaica to deal effectively with their pluricultural composition and entrenched social and racial divisions. H. Garcia Muñiz underscores the uneven power relations inherent in the metropolis-colony bond and how they have circumscribed the political status options in the unsovereign territories of Puerto Rico and the French and Dutch Caribbean. P. San Miguel deconstructs the divisive narrative that arbitrarily depicts the countries of Haiti and the Dominican Republic as "Black/African" and "Spanish-*mestizo*," respectively. R. Goddard surveys the impact of globalization in the region, where commercial agriculture has all but vanished and tourism has created a new dependency on foreign-owned hotel chains, airlines, cruise ships, as well as new problems associated with illegal narcotics and money laundering. The closing chapter by C. Du Bois addresses the centrality of regional and international migration to Caribbean peoples and the formation of diasporic communities in Europe, Latin America, the United States, and Canada.

In a work of this size and breadth it would be nearly impossible to avoid the occasional omission, misprint, or misstatement. Fortunately, there are only a few of these. In the discussion about the topography of the islands, one reads, "still others, such as Montserrat, were so rugged in terrain that plantation agriculture never took

hold" (pp. 138–9). This seems to suggest that Montserrat was outside the plantation belt, but we learn later on that "By the early 19th century, 9 in 10 enslaved workers in Nevis, Montserrat, and Tobago toiled on sugar estates..." (p. 251). Another passage mentions the presence of enslaved woodcutters in British Honduras and Belize! (p. 252). The "Spanish" origins of José Martí's parents (p. 371), though widely accepted, omits that his mother was a Canary Islander. The reference to the spread of "Anglo-Saxon religion" (p. 380) seems unclear. The claim that "during the 16th and 17th centuries, Spanish and French powers dominated Caribbean sugar production" (p. 386) is less applicable to the Spanish Caribbean in the 17th century.

These minor blemishes aside, this compilation is an indispensable study guide and reference tool that should not be ignored by anyone who wishes to have a thorough understanding of the principal events that have contoured the evolution of the Caribbean and its people. This voluminous collection of essays, organized around thirty-eight succinct chapters filled with the latest scholarship on the subject, has several other strengths worth acknowledging: chronologically, it covers the entire pre- and post-Columbian periods; it is both territory-specific and trans-Caribbean in scope; it is concise and comprehensive, allowing readers to see the proverbial "trees" and "forest" simultaneously; and, finally, many of the contributions view local events within the larger regional framework without losing sight of the broader Atlantic and global context.

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